

“I have in **sincerity pledged myself to your service**, [just] as so **many of you** are **pledged to mine**.”

ELIZABETH II, CORONATION SPEECH, 1952

THROUGH THE AGES

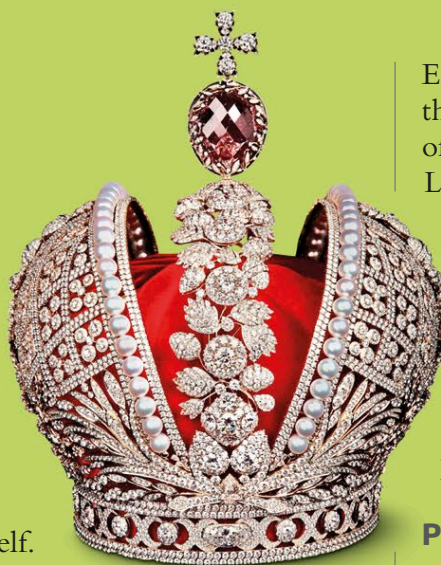
Royalty

Most kingdoms and empires favored male heirs when it came to passing on the crown. However, in spite of this, some remarkable women rose up to reign as queens in their own right, while others wielded considerable power as regents or wives of rulers.

TO ENSURE CONTINUITY, monarchies put laws and customs in place to determine the line of succession. Historically, the most widespread system was primogeniture, in which the firstborn, legitimate son of the ruler inherited, even if he had an older sister. However, if a ruler had only daughters, under this system the eldest became queen (or empress) regnant, ruling in her own right—as opposed to a “queen consort,” the spouse of a ruling king, or a “queen regent,” temporarily in charge on behalf of a king who was too young or too ill to make decisions for himself.

Many kings went to extreme lengths to secure a male heir, because it was believed that women were less fit to rule and would create instability in the line of succession. Most famously, in the 16th century, Henry VIII of England broke away from the Catholic Church in Rome to grant himself a divorce from Catherine of Aragon (the first of his six wives) so he could marry Anne Boleyn and try

to have a son. Henry eventually sired a male heir, Edward VI, who died childless and was succeeded by his older half-sisters: first Mary I, then Elizabeth I (see pp. 108–09). Other monarchs have changed laws to secure the succession for their daughters. Emperor Charles VI, ruler of the Austrian Habsburg realms, had no sons. Under the Pragmatic Sanction of 1713, he made concessions to other European powers so that they would recognize his daughter, Maria Theresa, as heir to his lands. However, when he died in 1740, Austria and its allies were forced to go to war against these powers to ensure her succession.



▲ Crown of Russia

This was the crown of Catherine the Great, who ruled Russia from 1762 to 1796. An enlightened monarch who corresponded with prominent thinkers of her day, she sought to modernize Russia through arts and education.

Elsewhere, some women have seized the throne for themselves. Empress Catherine I of Russia—a commoner from what is now Latvia—rose in station by marrying Peter the Great, then oversaw a coup after he died in 1725 to take power for herself. Although she only ruled for two years, she was the first female Russian ruler, setting a precedent for those that followed, such as Catherine II, the “Great,” who became the country’s most influential leader and its longest-ruling female monarch.

Patrilineal and matrilineal

Some countries followed (or still follow) the law of agnatic primogeniture, which skips royal women in line to the throne in favor of the nearest male relative. Even in these cases, however, it has still been possible for queen regents (usually the spouse or mother of the monarch) to govern. For example, in France, where women could not legally ascend to the throne, there were queen regents. Two of the